

A white paper windmill with five blades is shown against a blurred background of a building. A small electronic circuit, possibly an Arduino Nano, is attached to the base of the windmill. The circuit has a red LED that is lit, and several colored wires (red, blue, black) are connected to it. The text "Sophie's فال/fall" is overlaid on the image.

Sophie's فال/fall



The title Sophie's فال/fall

1. It references William Styron's novel "Sophie's Choice", pointing to Sophie's unfortunate lack of control over her life choices, that eventually resulted her destruction, or her "fall".
2. The word فال in Farsi, reads "fall", meaning omen, such as *fall-e-Hafez*, as in Sophie's readings.

Sophie's فال/fall is an Interactive sound installation

that combines technological elements, my personal background and culture and the act of interaction to question influences such as beliefs and traditions, the media and our tech-driven lifestyle.

A room full of paper windmills is the main interface to access a soundscape of layered voices; poems that rise and fall with the movement produced from the intentional blowing by participants or from unexpected winds that invade and circulate the space.

Each sound consists of a female voice (my voice) reading out lines of ghazals¹ from the great poet Hafez² The reader struggles linguistically, often stops or repeats to find the correct pronunciation and rhythm of the rhymes; and at times one can detect such struggle. However, the majority of time neither the language nor the way it is spoken, is clear to the ear, the compact layering of the sound, silences its meaning.

Apart from admiration for Hafez's lyric poetry or "ghazals" as a part of my cultural heritage, the fascination also roots in a tradition of fortune-telling using "Hafez's Divan", called "fall-e Hafez".

When we engage in an act fortune reading we choose to subscribe to the metaphysical, the idea of an existing collective consciousness, one that is wise and ancient. As a folkloric act, deeply connected to the roots of each place, cultures in different parts of the world have developed unique sets of rituals for tapping into this collective consciousness, looking for meaning in our human condition from "beyond", the past, the future, or the stars above.

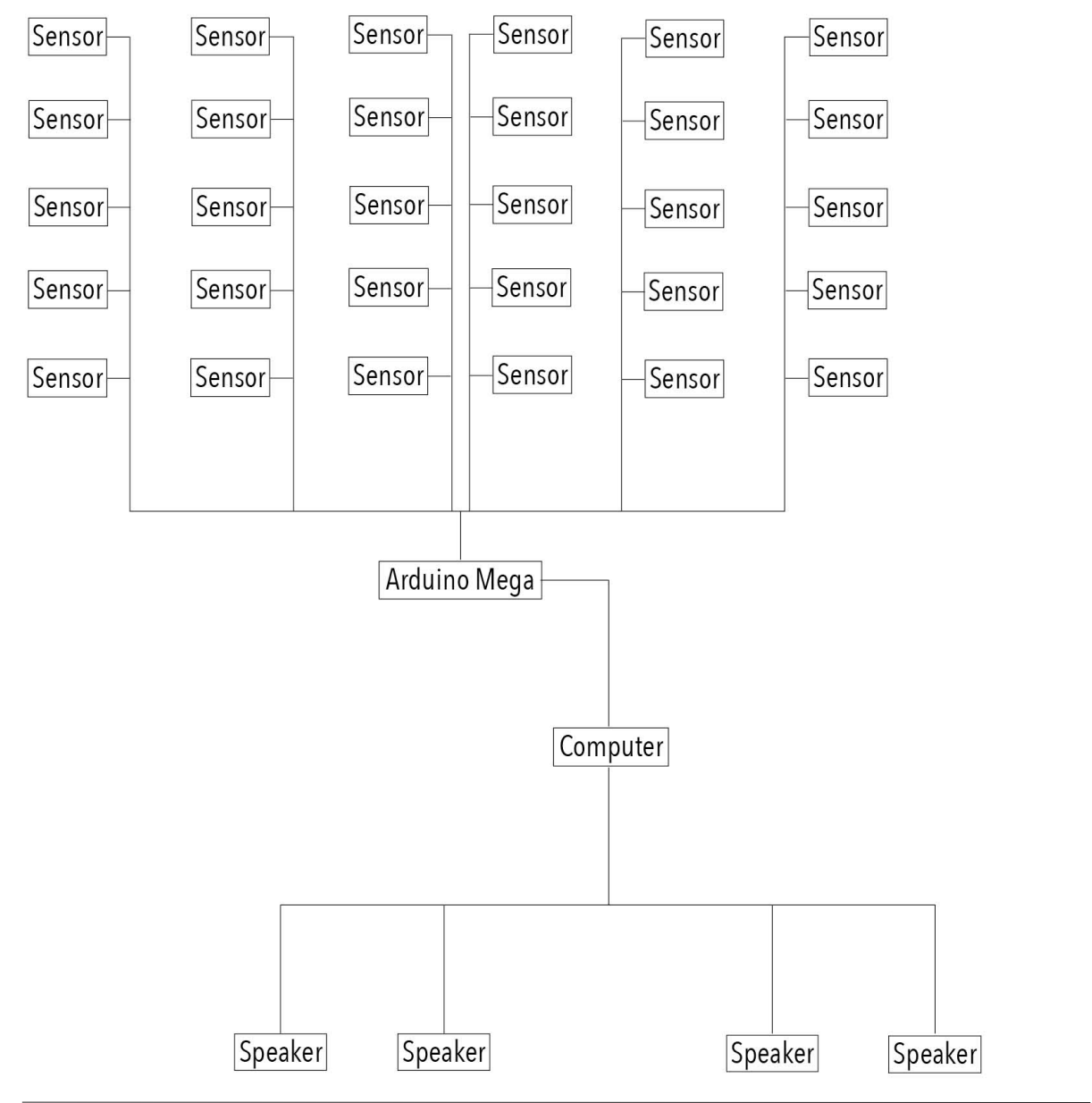
In Sophie's fall I share readings of my fortune; a fortune that I cannot understand or properly read. A fortune that through the verses transforms into juxtaposed ideas triggered by the will of others or simply the wind.

Windmills are reminiscence of childhood and play; an invitation for interaction and dialogue. The installation is put together primitively using pieces of wood and threads to hang the objects in the space. Cables and sensors are connected to every windmill and create an electronic system that links the space to computers. This combination of traditional and simple elements with the technological, computerised system is a portrait of ourselves in the forest of data.

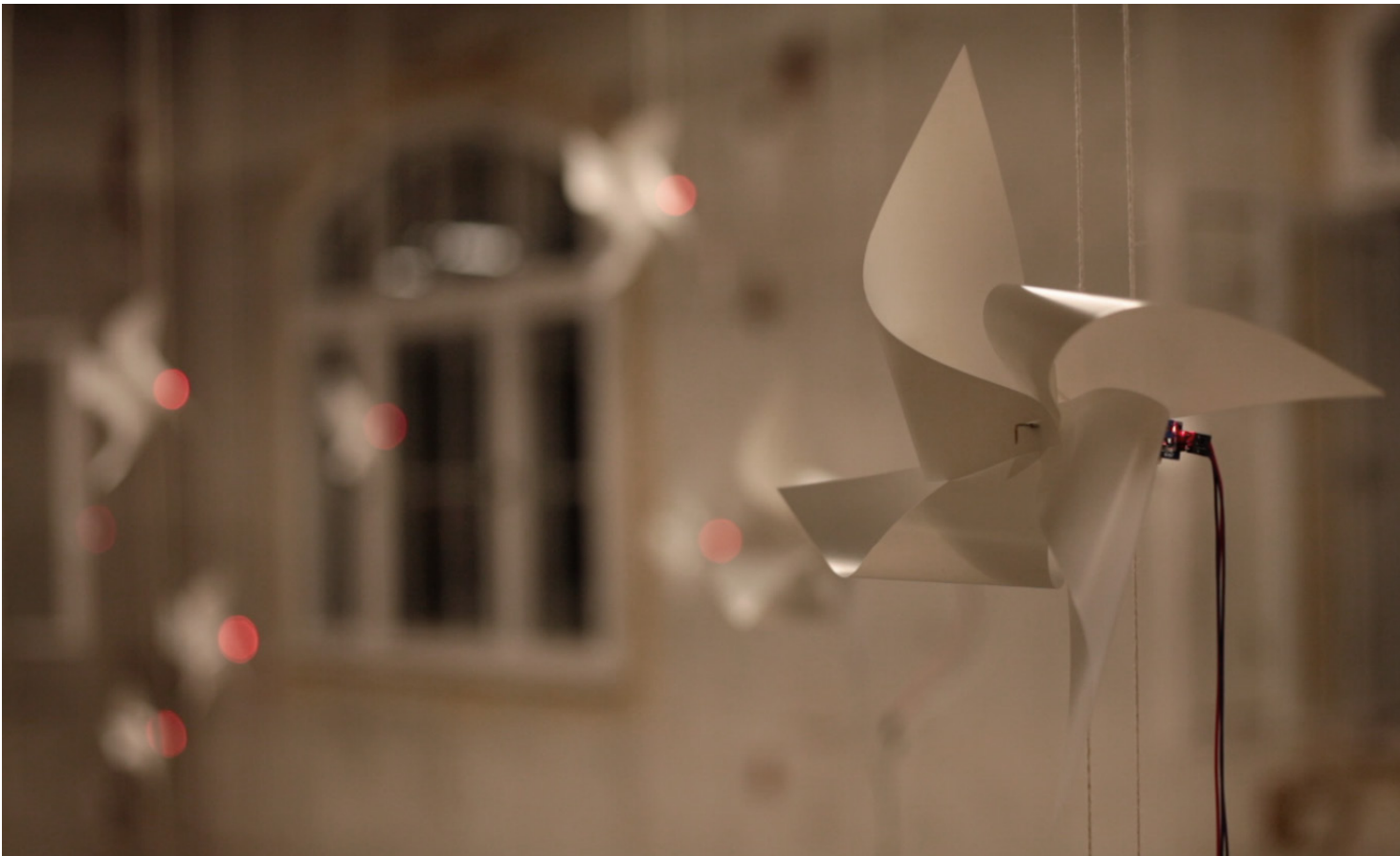
¹ The ghazal is a poetic form consisting of rhymes couplets and a refrains, with each line sharing the same meter. Traditionally invoking melancholy, love, longing and metaphysical questions, ghazals are often sung by Iranian, Indian and Pakistani poets and musicians. The form has its roots in seventh century Arabia, and gained prominence in thirteenth- fourteenth century thanks to such Persian poets as Rumi and Hafez.

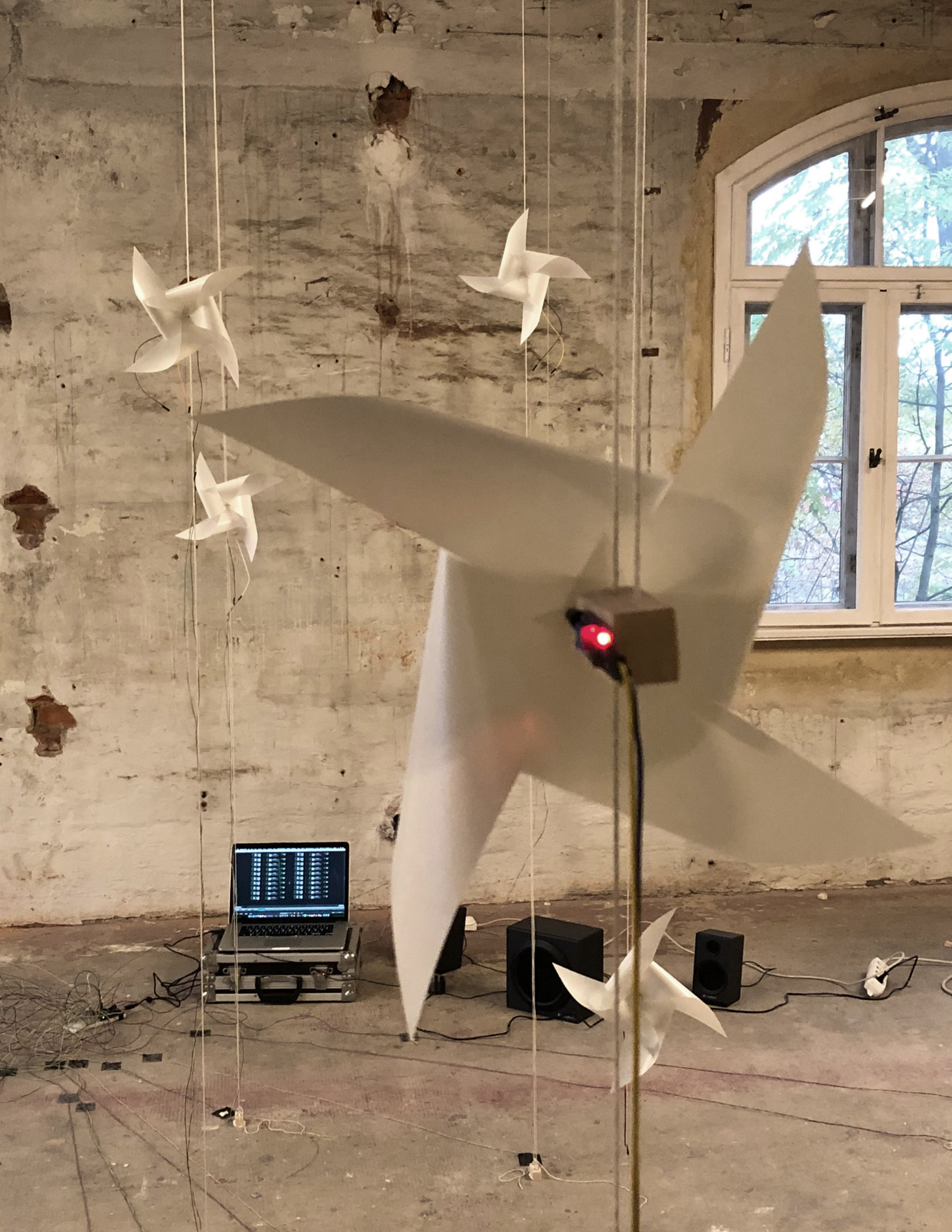
² Iranian poet Hafez (Khawja Shams-ud-Din Muhammad Hafez-e Shirazi) 1310-1390 expressing love, spirituality and protest in his many ghazals is one of the most celebrated Persian poets of all time.

Each of the 30 sensors used in the installation works as a RPM¹ counter. The function of the sensors is programmed using a microcontroller Arduino Mega², wich imports the incoming data (in real time) from the windmills to a computer. A patch³ developed in Pure Data⁴ decodes the data packages and transforms them into individual MIDI⁵ notes. These are then sent to a patch in Isadora⁶ where the audio layers and the volume of the prerecorded sounds are arranged.



¹ RPM stand for revolutions per minute, which is the number of turns in one minute.
² Arduino Mega is a microcontroller board with 54 input/output pin
³ a patch is a small piece of code inserted into a program
⁴ Pure Data is a visual programming language developed by Miller Puckette in 1990
⁵ MIDI Musical Instrument Digital Interface
⁶ Isadora is a proprietary graphic programming enviroment for real time manipulation of digital video sound and MIDI





Equipment and material

Construction of windmills:

Light sheets of paper or plastic,

Transparent glue

3 meter of metalic tube of 4mm

5 meter of metalic string of 2 mm,

Technical equipment:

Speaker system (preferably 4 monitors),

30 sensors

Arduino Mega

Cables to connect the sensors to the arduino (According to dimetions of the space)